

Advent of the Europeans in India

Portuguese, Dutch, English, Danish & French trading companies (1498–1757) — factories, wars, and the road to Plassey

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Why this chapter matters: This is the opening chapter of Modern Indian History and one of the most frequently tested static-GK blocks in SSC and Railway exams. Questions on "who came first", factory years, governors, and the Carnatic/Mysore Wars appear almost every recruitment cycle because they are precise, date-based, and easy to frame as one-liners — exactly the kind of question SSC favours.

1 Order of European Arrival in India

Five major European powers traded with India between the 15th and 18th centuries. **Arriving in India** and **setting up a company/factory** are two different things — always separate the two in your head.

Real-life example: Think of it like five delivery companies entering a new city. The first one to open a branch office isn't always the first one whose van is seen driving through town. Portuguese "vans" (ships) were seen first (1498), but British and Danish "branch offices" (companies) were registered before some others actually built a warehouse (factory).

Order	Power	First seen in India	Company/formal establishment
1	Portuguese	1498 (Vasco da Gama)	Crown-controlled, no "company" as such
2	Dutch	1598 (a visit)	VOC / Dutch East India Co. — 1602 (Netherlands)
3	English	1608 (Captain Hawkins, Surat)	English East India Co. — 31 Dec 1600 (charter)
4	Danish	—	Danish East India Co. — 1616
5	French	—	French East India Co. — 1664

MEMORY TRICK

"Please Deliver English Documents Fast" → Portuguese, Dutch, English, Danish, French — the exact chronological order.

HIGH FREQUENCY — "which power came first/last" is one of the most repeated SSC one-liners in this chapter.

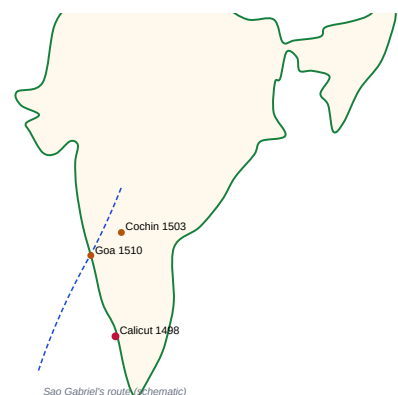
2 Portuguese Arrival — Vasco da Gama



Vasco da Gama reached India in **1498**, sailing from **Portugal** on a ship named **Sao Gabriel**, in search of a direct sea route for the **spice trade** — mainly **black pepper**. He landed at **Calicut (Kerala)**, where the local ruler, the **Zamorin**, welcomed him.

Real-life example: Think of Vasco da Gama as a delivery-app founder who cut out the middleman. Before him, Indian spices reached Europe through a long chain of Arab and Venetian traders (with everyone taking a cut). Da Gama's sea route let Portugal buy pepper directly from Kerala — instantly undercutting the old land-based trade network. That's why every European power raced to copy him.

He was guided across the Arabian Sea by a Gujarati Muslim navigator, commonly named in textbooks as **Abdul Majeed** (his name appears with spelling variants in different sources — the lecture calls him "Abul Munif"/"Ibn Majeed"). Da Gama met him on the African coast before crossing to Calicut.



Vasco da Gama's landing point and the first Portuguese strongholds on India's west/south-west coast.

Remember: "Arriving in India" (1498) and "setting up a permanent factory" (1503, Cochin) are different dates — SSC loves testing this gap.

3 Portuguese Governors / Viceroys 🔥

Only **three** Portuguese officials actually held the title of **Viceroy/Governor** in this early period. Pedro Alvares Cabral (1500–01) was a **commander**, not a viceroy — he is famous for accidentally discovering **Brazil** while sailing towards India.

MEMORY TRICK

"**All Great Nuns**" — Almeida → Albuquerque → Nuno da Cunha, in that order, for the three real governors.

Governor	Tenure	Known for
Francisco de Almeida	1505–1509	"Blue Water Policy" (also called the Cartaz system) — any ship sailing the Indian Ocean had to buy a pass from the Portuguese
Alfonso de Albuquerque	1509–1515	Real founder of Portuguese power in India (maximum territorial expansion); won the Battle of Diu (1509) and Battle of Goa (1510) against Yusuf Adil Shah of Bijapur, capturing Goa
Nuno da Cunha	1529–1538	Associated with the death of Bahadur Shah, the ruler of Gujarat

⚠️ Contradiction flagged

The lecture states Goa was captured in "1499" at one point, then self-corrects to **1510**. **1510** (Battle of Goa, Albuquerque vs Yusuf Adil Shah) is the standard, correct date — 1499 is simply too early, since Albuquerque's own tenure only began in 1509.

First Portuguese factory & fort

- First (temporary, failed) factory: **Cochin, 1500**
- First permanent factory: **Cochin, 1503**
- First fort built by the Portuguese in India was also at **Cochin** — an NDA (UPSC) PYQ

PYQ: Who is considered the real founder of Portuguese power in India? **Ans: Alfonso de Albuquerque**

4 Dutch (Netherlands) 🔥

The **Dutch** were the **first to bring a joint-stock company model** to Indian trade — ownership was split between Dutch merchants and shared risk/profit structures, unlike the Crown-run Portuguese trade.

Real-life example: A joint-stock company works like a modern startup raising money from many investors instead of one rich founder funding everything alone — spreading risk so a single bad voyage doesn't bankrupt one person.

- First visited India: **1598**
- **Dutch East India Company (VOC)** founded in the Netherlands: **1602**
- First Dutch factory in India: **Masulipatnam, 1605** — the first Dutch factory on Indian soil
- Chinsura factory (Bengal): established **1653–55**

Also had factories at: Masulipatnam, Pulicat, Nagapatnam, Chinsura, Surat, Bharuch, Ahmedabad — but never at Agra or Patna (a common "all of the above" trap in MCQs).

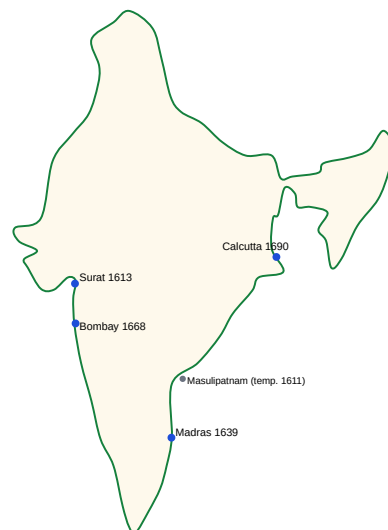
⚠️ Note on Hooghly vs Chinsura

Some books say the Dutch/Portuguese factory in Bengal was at **Hooghly**; the standard SSC answer for the **Dutch** Bengal factory is **Chinsura** (1653–55). **Hooghly** itself was actually a **Portuguese** stronghold — captured and held by them until the **Battle of Hooghly (1632)**, when Shah Jahan's forces (sent under Qasim Khan) drove them out. Keep these two separate: Hooghly = Portuguese; Chinsura = Dutch.

5 English East India Company 🔥

Queen **Elizabeth I** granted a royal charter on **31 December 1600** to a group led by **John Lancaster** (representing about 50 merchants), creating what would become the East India Company. Its original name was "**The Company of Merchants of London Trading into the East Indies**" — not the earlier **Levant Company (1592)**, which is a tempting but incorrect distractor in MCQs.

English embassies to the Mughal court: Captain **William Hawkins** reached **Jahangir's** court in **1608** (arriving on the ship *Hector*); Sir **Thomas Roe** followed in **1615**, securing trading rights. The company's first permanent Indian factory was established during **Jahangir's** reign.



The four English "presidency" anchor points and the earlier temporary factory at Masulipatnam.

English factory timeline

Year	Place	Note
1611	Masulipatnam	First factory, but temporary — did not last
1613	Surat	First permanent English factory
1639	Madras	Fort St. George built; grew into Madras Presidency
1668	Bombay	Received from the Portuguese as dowry (see below)
1690	Calcutta	Founded by Job Charnock

MEMORY TRICK

"So Many Bags Come" — Surat(1613) → Madras(1639) → Bombay(1668) → Calcutta(1690).

How the English got Bombay

In **1661**, England's King **Charles II** married the Portuguese princess **Catherine of Braganza**. Bombay came to England as part of her **dowry**. In **1668**, Charles II handed Bombay over to the English East India Company for a nominal annual rent.

Real-life example: Exactly like a wedding gift of property that the groom later leases out to a business — Bombay changed hands twice (Portugal → the King → the Company) without a single battle.

How Calcutta was founded

In **1690**, **Job Charnock** leased three villages — **Sutanuti, Kalikata, and Govindpur** — which grew into the city of Calcutta. A separate figure, **Gerald Aungier**, is credited as the architect who built up the city of **Bombay** (1669 onward) — don't mix the two names up.

PYQ: Who is regarded as the founder of Calcutta? **Ans: Job Charnock**

Municipal Corporation & other English "firsts"

- First municipal corporation in India: **Madras** — established **1687**, began functioning **1688** (both dates are seen in sources; know both).
- Sir **John Child**, an English governor, was expelled by **Aurangzeb** in **1681** for trading in violation of Mughal orders.
- Allahabad (Prayagraj) fort came under British control in the late 18th century, after Buxar-era treaties reorganised control of the region (exact year is a rare, UPPSC-style question, not core SSC syllabus).

Why the English ultimately succeeded over other Europeans (a favourite "reason" MCQ): stronger naval/military organisation, better-trained (Western-style) army, lack of unified nationalist resistance in India at the time, and shrewd exploitation of local political rivalries. Exam MCQs on this often expect "all of the above".

The **Danish East India Company** was formed in **1616**. Their first Indian factory was at **Tranquebar, Tamil Nadu**, established in **1620**.

⚠ Contradiction flagged

The lecture names the first Danish factory location as "**Travancore**" — this is incorrect. **Travancore** is a kingdom in **Kerala**; the actual Danish factory town, **Tranquebar**, is on the **Tamil Nadu** coast (near Tanjore). Always write **Tranquebar** in your answer, not Travancore.

The Danes later also held **Serampore** in Bengal, which became their main Indian headquarters. Both Tranquebar and Serampore were eventually sold to the British in 1845.

7 French East India Company & Dupleix 🔥

The **French East India Company** was established in **1664** under King **Louis XIV**, on the initiative of his minister **Jean-Baptiste Colbert** — considered the founder of French trading interest in India.

- First French factory: **Surat, 1668**
- Second French factory: **Masulipatnam, 1669**
- Strategic French centre in India: **Pondicherry**

Real-life example: Dupleix's strategy of "meddling" in local succession disputes to grab territory works exactly like a mediator who "settles" a family property dispute — and then quietly keeps a share of the land for himself as a "fee". In Hindi this trick is nicknamed **bandarbaat** (the monkey's share), because in the parable of two cats and a monkey dividing a piece of bread, the monkey — the supposed neutral judge — ends up eating almost all of it.

Joseph François Dupleix, the French Governor, pioneered this policy of intervening in Indian princely disputes to expand territorial influence — and his skill is why the French won the **First Carnatic War**.

⚠ Why the French ultimately lost to the British in the Deccan

It was **not** because Dupleix was a weak commander (he was, in fact, one of the ablest French commanders of the era) or because Indians disliked the French. The real reason was that the **British had a stronger, larger, and better-financed army/navy** in the region — a purely military and resource imbalance, not a leadership or public-opinion failure.

8 The Carnatic Wars (Anglo-French Rivalry) 🔥

MEMORY TRICK

Carnatic Wars = the South-Indian "sub-plot" of the wider European wars back home. Each Carnatic War lines up with a European war: 1st with the War of Austrian Succession, 3rd with the Seven Years' War.

War	Years	Ended by	Result / Note
1st Carnatic War	1746–1748 (roots from 1740)	Treaty of Aix-la-Chapelle (1748)	French win — Dupleix captures Madras (1746) with naval support from La Bourdonnais
2nd Carnatic War	1749–1754	No formal treaty — inconclusive	Fought over rival claimants to Carnatic/Hyderabad thrones
3rd Carnatic War	1756/57–1763	Treaty of Paris (1763)	Part of the global Seven Years' War; British emerge dominant, French power in India permanently curtailed

Madras itself was originally founded/settled by an Englishman, **Francis Day**, in 1639, but was **captured by the French under Dupleix in 1746** during the First Carnatic War, only to be returned to Britain by the 1748 treaty.

9 A Quick Look Ahead — Mysore Wars ★

The four Anglo-Mysore Wars (fought against **Hyder Ali** and later **Tipu Sultan**) are usually taught as part of the "Expansion of British Rule" chapter, but the lecture previews them here, so a quick summary:

War	Years	Note
1st Mysore War	1767–1769	Ended with Treaty of Madras; Hyder Ali held the advantage
2nd Mysore War	1780–1784	Ended with Treaty of Mangalore
3rd Mysore War	1790–1792	Ended with Treaty of Seringapatam; Tipu ceded half his territory

War	Years	Note
4th Mysore War	1799	Tipu Sultan killed at Seringapatam; Mysore kingdom dismantled

⚠ Contradiction flagged

The lecture states that **Robert Clive personally fought and lost** to Hyder Ali in the First Mysore War (1767–69). This is **incorrect**. Clive had already left India for good by 1767; the Company's side in that war was led under Governor **Lord Verelst** (Madras Presidency forces, e.g. Colonel Joseph Smith). Clive's name is correctly associated with **Plassey (1757)** and **Buxar-era events**, not the Mysore Wars.

10 Battle of Plassey — The Turning Point

The **Battle of Plassey (1757)** is considered the **first decisive military success** of the English East India Company in India and the symbolic **start of British political dominance**. **Robert Clive** defeated **Siraj-ud-Daulah**, the Nawab of Bengal — helped decisively by the betrayal of Siraj's own commander, **Mir Jafar**, who switched sides for the promise of the throne.

Real-life example: Plassey is often compared to a company takeover where the "outsider" investor wins not by outspending the rival, but by quietly buying out the rival's own board members beforehand. Clive's real victory was political — bribing Mir Jafar — more than military.

Related fact: Historian/administrator **Edmund Burke** (not covered in depth here but often quoted) and reformer **Lord Macaulay** are both linked with East-India-Company-era commentary; specifically, **T. B. Macaulay** is remembered for introducing the **English Education Act, 1835** in India.

PYQ: Which battle marked the beginning of British dominance in India? **Ans: Battle of Plassey (1757)**

PYQ: Who betrayed Siraj-ud-Daulah at Plassey? **Ans: Mir Jafar**

11 Opium & Saltpetre Trade

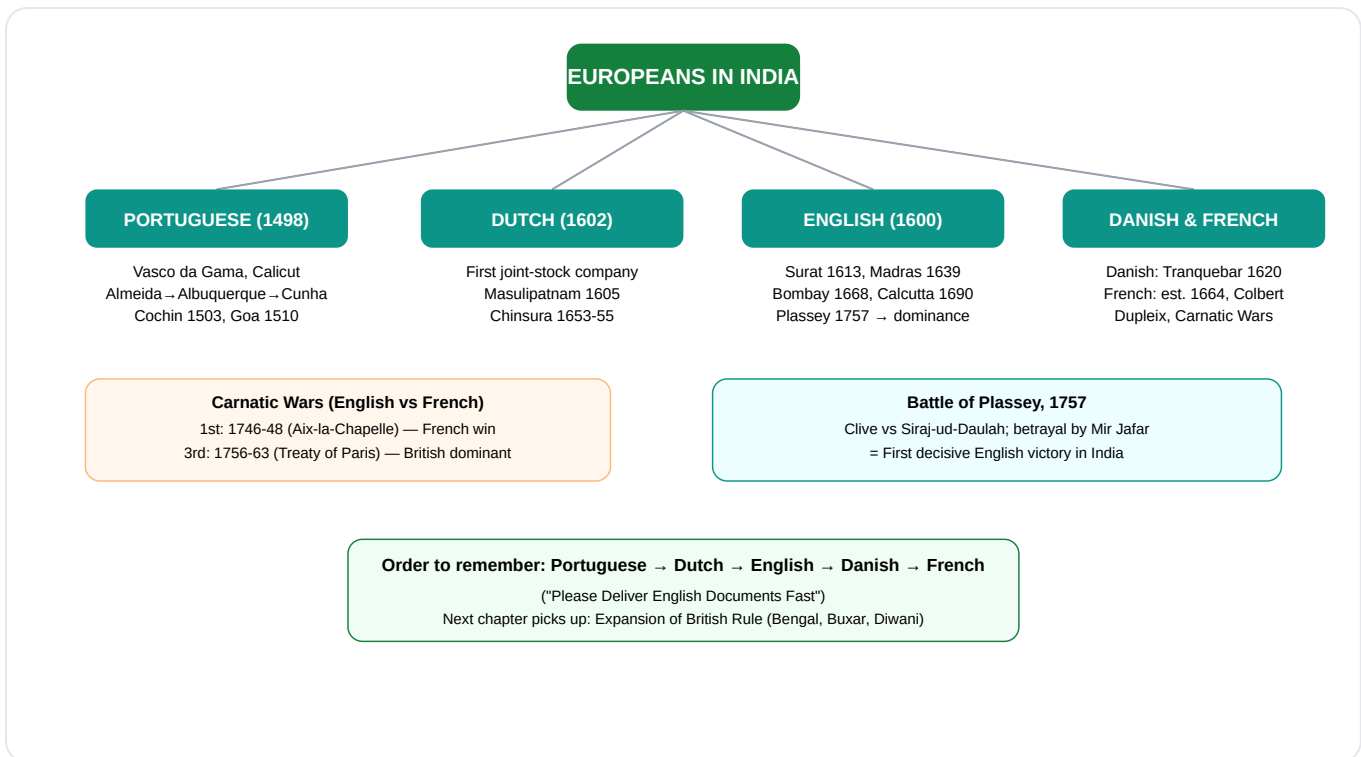
Among the goods Europeans sought from India, **opium** and **saltpetre (shora)** were especially valuable. **Bihar** — not Bengal — had the single densest concentration of opium cultivation, thanks to its climate, even though opium was grown across the wider Bengal region too.

12 Master Reference Table — Records & Pairings

Superlative / Record	Answer
First European to reach India by sea	Vasco da Gama (Portuguese), 1498, at Calicut
Real founder of Portuguese power in India	Alfonso de Albuquerque
Discoverer of Brazil (by accident, en route to India)	Pedro Alvares Cabral
First joint-stock company to trade with India	Dutch (VOC)
First Dutch factory in India	Masulipatnam, 1605
First permanent English factory	Surat, 1613
Founder of Calcutta	Job Charnock, 1690
Architect/builder of Bombay city	Gerald Aungier
First Danish factory	Tranquebar, Tamil Nadu, 1620
Founder of the French East India Company	Colbert (under Louis XIV), 1664
"Father" of the policy of interfering in Indian succession disputes	Dupleix
First decisive English military victory in India	Battle of Plassey, 1757
English governor expelled by Aurangzeb	Sir John Child, 1681

Superlative / Record	Answer
Brought the English Education Act, 1835	T. B. Macaulay

13 Mind Map — Advent of the Europeans



14 30-Second Revision

Fact	Value
Order of arrival	Portuguese → Dutch → English → Danish → French
Vasco da Gama	1498, Sao Gabriel, Calicut, welcomed by Zamorin
Real founder of Portuguese power	Albuquerque
First English permanent factory	Surat, 1613
Founder of Calcutta	Job Charnock, 1690
Danish first factory	Tranquebar (Tamil Nadu), 1620
French East India Co.	1664, under Louis XIV / Colbert
Turning-point battle	Plassey, 1757 (Clive vs Siraj-ud-Daulah)

15 PYQs from the Video (with Answers)

1. Who established trade relations with India first in the medieval period?

Portuguese **Ans: Portuguese**

2. When did Vasco da Gama reach India, and where?

Ans: 1498, Calicut

3. Who welcomed Vasco da Gama at Calicut?

Ans: The Zamorin

4. Who was the first Portuguese Viceroy in India?

Ans: Francisco de Almeida

5. Where did the Portuguese build their first fort in India?

Ans: Cochin

6. Real founder of Portuguese power in India?

Ans: Alfonso de Albuquerque

7. Who discovered Brazil while sailing towards India?

Ans: Pedro Alvares Cabral

8. Which Bengal factory did the Portuguese hold (via the Hooghly Battle, 1632)?

Ans: Hooghly

9. Which Bengal factory did the English first establish (per the video's Bengal timeline)?

Ans: 1611 Masulipatnam (temp.), permanently at Surat 1613; Bengal factories covered in the next chapter

10. First joint-stock company to trade with India?

Ans: Dutch (VOC)

11. First Dutch factory in India, and year?

Ans: Masulipatnam, 1605

12. Founder of Calcutta?

Ans: Job Charnock, 1690

13. Who built up the city of Bombay?

Ans: Gerald Aungier

14. First municipal corporation in India?

Ans: Madras (1687/1688)

15. First joint-stock company to trade with India was formed by whom?

Ans: The Dutch

16. Reason for East India Company's success in India?

Ans: All of the given reasons (Western military training, lack of Indian nationalism, exploiting local rivalries)

17. Where did the English establish their first (permanent) factory in 1613?

Ans: Surat

18. Where was the East India Company's very first (temporary) factory?

Ans: Masulipatnam, 1611

19. Bombay was taken by the English East India Company from whom?

Ans: The Portuguese (via royal dowry, then leased to the Company in 1668)

20. Who first established a factory at Surat among European companies?

Ans: The English (1613, permanent); Dutch and French came later at Surat too

21. Which fort came under English control in a given year (Prayagraj/Allahabad)?

Ans: Allahabad fort (rare UPPSC-style question, not core SSC)

22. Which English governor was expelled from India by a Mughal emperor?

Ans: Sir John Child, expelled by Aurangzeb, 1681

23. Between whom were the Carnatic Wars fought?

Ans: English and French

24. Which European first began the policy of interfering in Indian rulers' disputes to acquire territory?

Ans: Dupleix (French)

25. Which treaty ended which Carnatic War (match the following)?

Ans: 1st → Aix-la-Chapelle(1748); 2nd → no treaty; 3rd → Treaty of Paris(1763)

26. Where did the French establish their first factory in India?

Ans: Surat, 1668

27. Under whom was the French East India Company established?

Ans: Louis XIV, 1664

28. Who is regarded as the founder of the French company in India?

Ans: Colbert

29. Why did the French fail to establish supremacy in the Deccan?

Ans: The British army was stronger/better resourced (not because Dupleix was incapable)

30. Which factory in Bengal did the Dutch establish?

Ans: Chinsura

31. Correct chronological order of European arrival in India?

Ans: Portuguese → Dutch → English → Danish → French

32. Where did the Dutch establish their trading posts?

Ans: Masulipatnam, Chinsura, Nagapatnam (not Agra or Patna)

33. Region that supplied Europeans with the best saltpetre and opium?

Ans: Bihar

34. Which European power arrived last as a trader in pre-independence India?

Ans: French

35. Who called the East India Company "an anomaly... but part of a system where everything is anomalous"?

Ans: Edmund Burke

36. Which battle began British dominance in India?

Ans: Battle of Plassey, 1757

37. First decisive military success of the English East India Company in India?

Ans: Battle of Plassey, 1757

38. When was the Battle of Plassey fought, and who was defeated?

Ans: 1757; Siraj-ud-Daulah defeated by Robert Clive

39. Who is regarded as the founder of the British Empire in India?

Ans: Robert Clive (commonly cited answer; consolidation credited to later Governors-General too)

16 Extra Practice (Beyond the Video)

E1. In which year was the (English) East India Company granted its royal charter?

Ans: 31 December 1600

E2. Who guided Vasco da Gama from Africa to Calicut?

Ans: A Gujarati Muslim navigator, usually named Abdul Majeed/Ibn Majeed in textbooks

E3. What was the "Blue Water Policy" associated with Francisco de Almeida also called?

Ans: The Cartaz system

E4. Who defeated Yusuf Adil Shah at the Battle of Goa (1510)?

Ans: Alfonso de Albuquerque

E5. Which three villages merged to form Calcutta?

Ans: Sutanuti, Kalikata, Govindpur

E6. Which European power's headquarters in Bengal was at Serampore?

Ans: Danish

E7. Which act did T. B. Macaulay introduce in India, and in what year?

Ans: English Education Act, 1835

E8. Fort St. George, built in 1639, became the nucleus of which presidency?

Ans: Madras Presidency

E9. Who betrayed Siraj-ud-Daulah at Plassey, expecting to be made Nawab?

Ans: Mir Jafar

E10. Which treaty ended the Third Carnatic War, and what larger European war did it correspond to?

Ans: Treaty of Paris, 1763; corresponds to the Seven Years' War

E11. In which year did Charles II receive Bombay as a dowry, and from whose marriage?

Ans: 1661; his marriage to Catherine of Braganza of Portugal

E12. Who commanded the Mughal forces that expelled the Portuguese from Hooghly in 1632?

Ans: Qasim Khan, under Shah Jahan

E13. Sir John Child was expelled by which Mughal emperor, and in what year?

Ans: Aurangzeb, 1681

E14. What was Dupleix's territorial-expansion strategy nicknamed in Hindi?

Ans: "Bandarbaat" (the monkey's share)

E15. Who succeeded Hyder Ali as ruler of Mysore, and in which year did Hyder Ali die?

Ans: Tipu Sultan; Hyder Ali died in 1782, during the Second Mysore War

17 Bonus — Standard-Syllabus Points (Not in the Video)

These points are commonly tested alongside "Advent of Europeans" in SSC/Railway static-GK sections but were not covered in the lecture. Verified via web search against standard references (NCERT-aligned, exam-portal cross-checks).

- **Portuguese decline:** Their power waned after the loss of Hooghly (1632) and repeated Dutch/English pressure through the 17th century; the last Portuguese Indian territories (Goa, Daman, Diu) were only annexed by India in **1961** (Operation Vijay) — centuries after their trading dominance ended.
- **Vijaydurg / Maratha naval power** briefly checked European (mainly Portuguese and English) shipping along the west coast in the early 18th century under commanders from the Angre family — a syllabus point sometimes linked to this chapter's "decline of Portuguese/Dutch" theme.
- **Battle of Colachel (1741):** The Dutch suffered a rare and significant defeat at the hands of the Kingdom of Travancore under Marthanda Varma — considered one of the first major defeats of a European colonial power by an Indian state, and it effectively ended serious Dutch expansion ambitions in the subcontinent.
- **Treaty of Purandar / earlier Anglo-Maratha contact** and the **Battle of Buxar (1764)** — the sequel to Plassey, where Bengal's Nawab, the Mughal Emperor Shah Alam II, and Awadh's Nawab were jointly defeated by the British, and which led directly to the **Diwani of Bengal (1765)** — is the natural next milestone after Plassey and is covered in the next chapter of this series.
- **Sea route significance:** Da Gama's route round the **Cape of Good Hope** broke the Arab–Venetian monopoly on the spice trade — a key "why it matters" point examiners sometimes frame as a geography-history crossover question.

Cross-check all dates with your NCERT Class VIII "Our Past III" and Class XII Themes in Indian History-III for the standard textbook framing.

This is **Part 1 of an 8-part series** covering the full lecture. Bengal's own founding/Nawabs, the Battle of Buxar, and the Diwani grant are detailed in **Part 2: Expansion of British Rule in India**.